Winter is coming. For birders, that's not a *Game of Thrones* reference but a call to make travel plans as the migration season brings avian visitors to the subcontinent. Birders, for the uninitiated, are serious enthusiasts who make life lists and keep count of the species they see, while birdwatchers are mostly just casual observers. Birders may stretch their enthusiasm to great lengths, often making transcontinental air-hops to see their 'target species'. This kind of trophy-hunting, derisively called twitching, is not loved by climate activists. That said, as birding gains popularity, so have the destinations that birders seek out. This limited list of the top birding destinations in India is one that will most certainly ruffle some feathers.



Chukar Partridge

INDIA PICTURE

Eaglenest Wildlife Sanctuary, Arunachal Pradesh

Eaglenest is a small community-managed protected area in the north-east Indian state's Kameng Elephant Reserve. It shot to fame in 1995 with the discovery of a new bird species, the Bugun Liocichla, named after the Bugun community that inhabits the region. With great variations in altitude and vegetation, this dense forest landscape hosts over 450 bird species, including the Ward's Trogon, Sclater's Monal and the Rufous-necked Hornbill.



Black-faced Laughingthrush

INDIA PICTURE

Hemis National Park, Ladakh

This vast 4,400 sq. km wilderness area, just 10 km north of Leh, is famed for its snow leopard population. It is also on the radar of birders, who visit in late spring and early summer to watch high-altitude species such as the Snow Partridge, Snow Pigeon, Lammergeier and Himalayan Snowcock.

Mangalajodi Wetlands, Odisha

Just west of Chilika, India's largest brackish water lake, these freshwater wetlands in Odisha's Khordha district are easily approached by road or rail from Bhubaneswar. In winter, fisherfolk navigate the shallow marshes by flat-bottomed punts propelled with poles. The Mangalajodi Eco-tourism Centre, run by the local community, operates guided safari tours. The guides are rehabilitated poachers who now employ their exceptional field skills to great effect. Visit Mangalajodi in winter for great views of the Ruddy Shelduck, Northern Pintail, Slaty-breasted Rail, Gadwall, Common Teal and Glossy Ibis.



Ruddy Shelduck

Kaziranga National Park, Assam

Home to the Great Indian One-Horned Rhinoceros, Kaziranga is equally a magnet for birds, with over 470 species recorded in its forests, grasslands and riverine habitats. Birders flock here in winter to see the Bengal Florican, Pallas's Fish Eagle and Swamp Francolin.



Crimson Sunbird